However, despite its better manners, the group had no compunction about using fear and coercion to garner support, savagely punishing those who worked against it. Lashkar employed expressive violence to intimidate the local populace, mutilating informers and leaving them in the town square for all to see.[53] Although the group may have scaled back its open proselytizing, there were instances of Lashkar militants bullying others to adopt its interpretation of Islam. Sometimes this extended to taking over mosques belonging to other sects, primarily Barelvis, to preach the glories of the Ahl-e-Hadith creed. The group also engaged in violence to muscle its way onto the Ahl-e-Hadith scene in Indian-administered Kashmir.[54]

However, Lashkar mainly attacked Indian military targets, and often issued warnings to local Muslims to avoid Indian army camps and installations lest they be caught in the crossfire.[55] It attacked Hindu civilians as well, in some instances mutilating victims.[56] Gruesome attacks garnered publicity and intimidated the local non-Muslim populace, as well as disrupting peace negotiations and reigniting the conflict when it began to ebb. For example, Lashkar executed a massacre of Hindus in Doda one week after peace talks took place in 2001.[57] Over time the group had become infamous for these massacres. Despite its notorious reputation, Lashkar always maintained that killing civilians was against its religious beliefs. Hafiz Saeed declared doing so to be ‘totally un-Islamic’ and stated that ‘Our policy in this regard is crystal clear. We don’t want to target innocent civilians.’[58] In an attempt to avoid staining its reputation, Lashkar operated under different names. A Kashmiri who worked as a journalist in Indian-administered Kashmir and an Indian military officer who served there during the 1990s both noted that Lashkar used these assumed identities to take credit for operations in which it deliberately targeted civilians.[59]

A number of Indian experts who followed the Kashmir insurgency since its inception, as well as several former Indian military officers, suggested that Lashkar’s rise beginning in the mid-1990s coincided with an increase in the quality of combat engagements from a tactical perspective. By the end of the decade Indian forces considered Lashkar to be the best trained of all the militant groups operating in Kashmir.[60] This is not surprising given the level and type of support the group received. Although a nucleus of militants already existed, the army and ISI essentially built Lashkar’s